

Reading/Writing Review Materials

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1 Grammar and Syntax

1.1 Words

Words are, at least in an intuitive way, the building blocks of textual analysis.

1.1.1 Verbs

Verbs, sometimes called predicates, are “actions, events, states”, etc.; their basic function is to apply qualities to other words. Subcategories are:

- (I) finite: inflected (conjugated), i.e., modified with endings, according to number, person, tense, aspect, voice, and mood
 - (A) number (quantity of actor): singular, plural
 - (B) person (POV of actor): 1st, 2nd, 3rd
 - (C) voice (POV of action): active, middle (rare), passive
 - (D) tense (time of action): past, present, future
 - (E) aspect (type of action): simple, progressive, perfect(ive), perfect progressive
 - (F) mood (reality of action): indicative, imperative, subjunctive (rare)
- (II) nonfinite: inflected only for voice, tense, and aspect
 - (A) infinitive (verbal noun): bare verb or following *to*, usually a complement to a finite verb
 - (B) participle (verbal adjective): present (*-ing*), past (*-ed*), usually in a periphrastic form (below), as a complement to a finite verb, or as a subordination marker (below)
- (III) linking/copula: a form of *be* that describes one thing as another, usually two substantives
- (IV) periphrastic: one finite verb (the auxiliary/helping verb) plus one or more nonfinite verbs (usually a participle)
 - (A) using forms of *be* for passive voice
 - (B) using forms of *have* for perfective aspect
 - (C) using *will* or *going to* for future tense
 - (D) using modals for subjunctive moods: *can*, *could*, *may*, *might*, *must*, *shall*, *should*, *would*
- (V) paradigms
 - (1) indicative forms of *be* and *have* used to form periphrastic forms

	<i>be</i>		<i>have</i>	
	present	past	present	past
1s (<i>I</i>)	am	was	have	had
2s (<i>you</i>)	are	were	have	had
3s (<i>he/she/it</i>)	is	was	has	had
1p (<i>we</i>)	are	were	have	had
2p (<i>you (all)</i>)	are	were	have	had
3p (<i>they</i>)	are	were	have	had
participles	being	been	having	had
infinitive	(to) be		(to) have	

(2) full indicative paradigm of *break* (note: not all verbs will fill the entire paradigm)

mood	indicative											
voice	active											
tense	present				past				future			
aspect	simp	perf	prog	perf-prog	simp	perf	prog	perf-prog	simp	perf	prog	perf-prog
1s	break	present indicative of			broke	past indicative of			will or pres. ind. of <i>be</i> + <i>going to</i>			
2s	break	<i>have</i>	<i>be</i>	<i>have</i>		<i>have</i>	<i>be</i>	<i>have</i>		+	+	+
3s	breaks									+	+	+
1p	break			been				been		have	be	have been
2p	break	+	+	+		+	+	+	+	+	+	+
3p	break	broken	breaking			broken	breaking		break	broken	breaking	
part	breaking				—				—			
inf	(to) break											

mood	indicative											
voice	passive											
tense	present				past				future			
aspect	simp	perf	prog	perf-prog	simp	perf	prog	perf-prog	simp	perf	prog	perf-prog
1s	present indicative of				past indicative of				<i>will</i> or pres. ind. of <i>be</i> + <i>going to</i>			
2s	<i>be</i>	<i>have</i>	<i>be</i>	<i>have</i>	<i>be</i>	<i>have</i>	<i>be</i>	<i>have</i>	+	+	+	+
3s		+	+	+		+	+	+	be	have	be	have
1p		been	being	been being		been	being	been being		been	being	been being
2p	+	+	+	+	+	+	+	+	+	+	+	+
3p	broken				broken				broken			
part	—				(being/having) broken				—			
inf	(to) be broken											

Note that different forms can be difficult to distinguish. See the following examples:

- (3) examples with *be*
- a. I think that I **am** a dinosaur finite, indicative
 - b. I think that I **be** a dinosaur finite, subjunctive (archaic)
 - c. I think to myself, **be** a dinosaur finite, imperative
 - d. I think myself **to be** a dinosaur nonfinite, infinitival
 - e. I think of myself as one **being** a dinosaur nonfinite, participial

Note that periphrastic passive forms are best avoided in formal academic writing. See the differences between the following forms:

- (4) periphrastic passive, periphrastic progressive, non-periphrastic copula

- | | |
|--|------------------------------------|
| a. he was walloped (by the walloper) | simple past passive (avoid) |
| b. he was walloping (against the clobberer) | progressive past active |
| c. he was a wallop machine | simple past copula |

1.1.2 Nouns

Nouns, sometimes called substantives, are “persons, places, things’, etc.; their basic function is to refer to the objects in the world. Among other functions, nouns act as the subjects and direct/indirect objects of verbs, as well as agents for things being acted upon. A noun can, often must, be preceded by indefinite articles (*a/an*), definite articles (*the*), or demonstrative adjectives (below). Subcategories are:

- (I) lexical: basic referent, inflected (declined) for number only (singular, plural)
- (II) pronouns: nouns that (usually) have an antecedent (a referent in the local context)
 - (A) personal: inflected (declined) for number, gender, case
 - (i) number: singular, plural
 - (ii) gender: masculine, feminine, neuter
 - (iii) case: subjective (nominative), objective/oblique (accusative/dative), possessive (genitive)
 - (B) reflexive: forms with *-self / -selves*
 - (i) *myself, yourself, him-/her-/itself, ourselves, yourselves, themselves*
 - (C) pleonastic/dummy: *it* or *there* in subject position but that don’t refer to anything
 - (D) relative: governs its own clause in the same sentence as its antecedent
 - (i) basic: *who, whom, whose, that, which*
 - (ii) indefinite: *whoever, whomever, whosoever, whatever, whatsoever, whichever*
 - (E) interrogative: similar to relatives but used to form questions (no antecedent), direct or indirect
 - (i) *who, whom, whose, what, which*
 - (F) demonstrative: marks a particular antecedent based on context, identical to demonstrative adjectives
 - (i) *this/these/that/those*
- (III) verbal nouns
 - (A) gerunds: *-ing*, these look like present participles but act as nouns
 - (B) infinitives: rare but possible in English
- (IV) paradigm
 - (5) paradigm of English inflected nouns

		1st	2nd	3rd			
				personal	relative	interrog.	lexical
singular	subjective	I	you	he/she/it	who/that	who/what	human
	possessive	mine	yours	his/hers/its	whose	whose	human's
	objective	me	you	him/her/it	whom/that	whom/what	human
plural	subjective	we	you (all)	they	who/that	who/what	humans
	possessive	ours	yours / you all's	theirs	whose	whose	humans'(s)
	objective	us	you (all)	them	whom/that	whom/what	humans

Note that it can be difficult to determine when: i) verbal nouns and adjectives are acting as verbs or as nouns and ii) *wh*- words are acting as relative pronouns, interrogative pronouns, or adjectives. See the differences between the following forms:

(6) verbal nouns and adjectives

- a. **swimming** is good noun
- b. **to swim** is good noun
- c. he left (by) **swimming** verb
- d. he left (in order) **to swim** verb

(7) *wh*- words; *I knew ...*

- a. ... the person/thing **who/that** became the ghouls' treat relative pronoun
- b. ... the person/thing **whom/that** the ghouls made a treat relative pronoun
- c. ... **who/what** became the ghouls' treat interrogative pronoun
- d. ... **whom/what** the ghouls made a treat interrogative pronoun
- e. ... **what/which** person/thing became the ghouls' treat relative adjective

1.1.3 Adjectives/Adverbs

An adjective or adverb describes or refines some other entity.

(I) adjectives: often called determiners, modify nouns

(A) three functions: substantival, attributive, predicative

(8) three types of adjectives

- a. **green** made the big fish mad as hell substantival
- b. green made the **big** fish mad as hell attributive
- c. green made the big fish **mad** as hell predicative

(B) lexical: defines a particular property, has three degrees;

- (i) positive: *cool/good/puke-like*
- (ii) comparative: *cooler/better/more puke-like*
- (iii) superlative: *coolest/best/most puke-like*

(C) possessive: indicates possession (distinct from the possessive personal pronouns (above))

- (i) *my, your, his/her/its, our, your, their*
- (D) relative: refers to a prior antecedent and modifies a noun in its own clause;
 - (i) *what, which*
- (E) interrogative: used to form a question and modifies a noun
 - (i) *what, which*
- (F) demonstrative: marks out a particular noun, identical to the demonstrative pronouns (above)
- (II) adverbs: a kind of catchall category, can modify everything except (directly) nouns
 - (A) lexical: usually formed by adding *-ly* to adjectives
 - (i) positive: *quickly*
 - (ii) comparative: *more quickly*
 - (iii) superlative: *most quickly*
 - (B) negations: *not, never*, etc.
 - (C) temporal: *when, after, before*, etc.
 - (D) a large set of otherwise unclassifiable words

1.1.4 Prepositions

A preposition locates or relates nouns to something; i.e., it requires a noun to follow it. English also has some postpositions, which follow the nouns they modify. Attributes:

- (I) particularly productive in English and make up a large set of words
- (II) multiple words can make up one preposition (e.g., *on top of*)
- (III) often semantically attached to verbs (e.g., *up* in *wash up*)

1.1.5 Conjunctions

A conjunction combines entities (words, phrases, clauses). Subcategories:

- (I) coordinating (equal status): *and, but, for, nor, or, so, yet*
- (II) subordinating (unequal status): *after, although, as, as if, because, before, even if, even though, if, if only, rather than, since, that, though, unless, until, when, where, whereas, wherever, whether, which, while*
- (III) correlative: *both/and, whether/or, either/or, neither/nor, not/but, not only/but also, as/as, such/that, scarcely/when, as many/as, no sooner/than, rather/than*

Note that it can be difficult to distinguish when a word is acting as an adverb, a preposition, or a conjunction. In fact, most prepositions in English can act as adverbs and can only be distinguished based on whether or not the word takes a nominal object.

- (9) adverb, preposition, conjunction
- | | |
|---|--------------------|
| a. the monster never cried before | adverb |
| b. the monster never cried before bedtime | preposition |
| c. the monster never cried before it went to bed | conjunction |

1.2 Phrases

Phrases are single words or groups of words with some kind of recognizable semantic content (“meaning”). They are labeled based on the main word, the “head”, of the phrase, e.g.:

- (10) I didn’t know what to do [CnP while [VP sitting [PP next to [NPthe [AP [AdvP very] unhappy] gorilla]]]
- CnP, conjunction phrase (subordinate clause (see below)): **while** ... gorilla
 - VP, verb (participial) phrase: **sitting** ... gorilla
 - PP, prepositional phrase: **next to** ... gorilla
 - NP, noun phrase: **the** ... **gorilla**
 - AP, adjectival phrase: very **unhappy**
 - AdvP, adverbial phrase: **very**

1.3 Clauses

Clauses are the smallest sets of words that have propositional content. Attributes:

- required constituents
 - a subject, usually a noun, which can be implied
 - a predicate, usually a verb
- types
 - finite: headed by a finite verb (above)
 - nonfinite: headed by a nonfinite verb (above)
- functions
 - main/independent/matrix: “complete” by itself
 - subordinate/dependent/embedded: “incomplete” by itself, usually headed by a subordinating conjunction, a participle, or a *wh*- word
 - a finite clause can be either independent or dependent, but a nonfinite clause (in normal grammatical circumstances) can only be dependent; i.e., independent clauses are always finite.

1.4 Sentences

Sentences are the smallest set of words that are grammatically valid on their own.

(I) types

- (A) simple: one independent clause
- (B) compound: two or more independent clauses
- (C) complex: one independent clause and one or more dependent clauses
- (D) complex-compound: at least two independent clauses and at least one dependent clause

1.5 Important Structural Types

(I) parataxis: a combination of entities with equal status

- (A) compound sentences are one example
- (B) possible kinds, entities that are ...
 - (i) simply set side-by-side
 - (ii) combined with coordinating conjunctions and commas
 - (iii) combined with coordinating grammatical marks (clause final marks, i.e. semi-colons, periods, question marks, exclamation marks)
- (C) can be temporal, concessive, causal, resultative, purposive, or conditional

(11) paratactic constructions

- | | |
|--|--------------------|
| a. I climbed a big tree, and (=and then) I saw a great foe | temporal |
| b. I climbed a big tree, and (=even though) I rarely climb trees | concessive |
| c. I climbed a big tree, and (=because) before I saw a great foe | causal |
| d. I climbed a big tree, and (=and thereby) I scratched my pinky toe | resultative |
| e. I needed to escape my enemy, and (therefore) I climbed a big tree | purposive |
| f. I can't climb trees by myself, and you (if you do) can help me | conditional |

(II) hypotaxis: a combination of entities with unequal status

- (A) complex sentences are one example
- (B) possible kinds, entities that are:
 - (i) simply set side-by-side, the second item subordinate
 - (ii) combined with subordinating conjunctions or commas
 - (iii) combined with other subordinating words, usually participles of adverbs
 - (iv) combined with subordinating grammatical marks (commas, colons, em-dashes)
- (C) can be temporal, concessive, causal, purposive, or conditional

(12) hypotactic constructions

- | | |
|--|--------------------|
| a. after climbing the big tree, I saw a great foe | temporal |
| b. despite rarely climbing trees, I climbed a big tree | concessive |
| c. by climbing a big tree, I scratched my pinky toe | causal |
| d. by climbing a big tree, I tried to escape my enemy | purpose |
| e. by climbing a big tree, I might escape my enemy | conditional |

(III) conditionals: sentences that set up a real or imagined cause (the condition, called the protasis or antecedent) and a possible effect (called the apodosis or consequent). The protasis usually begins with *if* and sometimes with just the subjunctive *were*, and the apodosis starts with nothing or, optionally, with *then*.

(A) paradigm

(13) conditional sentence types

type	usage	protasis	apodosis	example
zero	general truths	simple present	simple present	if this happens, that happens
one	possibility (real) → probability	simple present	simple future	if this happens, that will happen
two	present hypothetical (unreal) → present probability	simple past	present conditional or present progressive conditional	if this happened, that would happen / would be happening
three	past hypothetical (unreal) → past probability	past perfect	perfect conditional	if this had happened, that would have happened / would have been happening
mixed	past hypothetical (unreal) → present probability	past perfect	present conditional	if that had happened, this would happen

Note that in academic writing it is best to avoid dangling modifiers, i.e., agent mismatches between a subordinate and main clause

(14) dangling modifiers

- | | |
|---|----------------------|
| a. after eating ten pies, my stomach exploded | ungrammatical |
| b. after I ate ten pies, my stomach exploded | grammatical |
| c. after trying to digest ten pies, my stomach exploded | grammatical |

2 Prosody

Understanding and describing a text's sound patterns is almost always important and illuminating.

- (I) rhythm: the most general/high-order category of prosody—what a poem, sentence, or line ‘sounds like’; describable in terms like ‘flowing’, ‘choppy’, etc.
- (II) meter: a formal/analyzable rhythmic structure, comprising numbered amounts of a specific foot type
 - (A) monometer = 1 foot; dimeter = 2 feet; trimeter = 3 feet; tetra- = 4; penta- = 5; hexa- = 6; hepta- = 7; octa- = 8
 - (B) foot: a pattern comprising a set amount of marked (stressed or long) and unmarked (unstressed or short) quantities (syllables or sets of syllables)
 - (C) English uses a stress-based meter using discrete syllables, where number of syllables usually equals number of vowels; ́ = stressed, ̀ = unstressed
 - (i) pyrrhus/dibrach: ̀ ̀ (*and the feast*) [rare]
 - (ii) iamb: ̀ ́ (*divide*) [very common]
 - (iii) trochee: ́ ̀ (*dimly*) [very common]
 - (iv) spondee: ́ ́ (*eat now*) [common]
 - (v) tribrach: ̀ ̀ ̀ (*curatedly*) [rare]
 - (vi) anapest: ̀ ̀ ́ (*it went underneath*) [moderately common]
 - (vii) amphibrach: ́ ̀ ̀ (*divinely*) [uncommon]
 - (viii) dactyl: ́ ̀ ̀ (*finally*) [moderately common]
 - (ix) bacchius: ̀ ́ ́ (*the big bugs*) [rare]
 - (x) cretic: ́ ̀ ́ (*incorrect*) [rare]
 - (xi) antibacchius: ́ ́ ̀ (*small biting*) [rare]
 - (xii) molossus: ́ ́ ́ (*big time fun*) [rare]
 - (D) a word's stress pattern can be different in a metered line than by itself
 - (E) other terms
 - (i) line: the basic unit that defines the text's meter (e.g., a line of tetrameter)
 - (ii) caesura: traditionally, a pause within a line that separates two logical parts, without a meter break; also can refer to a break in the meter within a line
 - (iii) enjambment: continuation of a phrase across a line break, such that the meter of each respective line remains unchanged
 - (F) in metered works, a break/change/deviation in the meter often suggests something textually significant
 - (G) iambic pentameter is historically the default meter of English verse
- (III) sound patterns

- (A) rhyme: repetition of a word's ending sound
 - (i) off/slant rhyme: near, not exact, repetition of an ending sound
 - (ii) masculine rhyme: a rhyme with one, stressed syllable
 - (iii) feminine rhyme: rhyme with one stressed and one unstressed syllable
 - (iv) apocopated rhyme: a mixed masculine/feminine rhyme
- (B) assonance: repetition of a vowel sound
- (C) consonance: repetition of a consonant sound
- (D) alliteration: repetition of initial sounds, whether vowel or consonant
- (E) sound patterns often suggest words/ideas are being paired for some purpose/meaning

3 Reading and Writing

3.1 Tips for Analyzing Sentences

Many sentences are difficult to parse and understand, especially in literary and theoretical texts. These steps can be used to decode tough sentences.

- (I) Locate the verbs. Most of the time, sentences have one verb per clause, so, for particularly labyrinthine sentences, the verbs will act as the backbone. This won't always be the case, and some verb-like instances can be misleading, e.g., gerunds, which look like verbs. Starting with finite verbs is usually easiest.
- (II) Note the difference between grammatical roles and syntactic roles. The most important distinction is between the subject of a sentence, the thing that governs verb agreement (grammatical), and the agent of a sentence, the thing doing the action of the verb (syntactic). The most common example of this is the standard passive construction, in which the grammatical subject is the syntactic object: e.g., *the store* [subject] *was robbed by the local fascists* [agent].
- (III) Account for the necessary roles of each verb. E.g., a verb like *destroy* almost always requires a direct object. If a verb seems to be missing one or some of its roles, find or account for it (perhaps in unintuitive ways). If a verb has one of its roles already accounted for, likely some other entity in the sentence won't also be used for that role, and that second entity will be used for a different role.
- (IV) Be precise about the exact relationships between clauses. If a sentence doesn't make sense when its clauses are viewed as being temporally related, try thinking about them as, e.g., causally related. A good way to start is by locating what the main "idea" or "point" of the sentence might be, and then to figure out what subsidiary points are. Look especially for parentheticals or appositive phrases (often surrounded by commas), to rule them out as being not main clauses.
- (V) Similarly, find the "break" points: where logic changes or is missing/confused, where prosody/sound changes, where there are harsh grammatical moves or changes of speaker/tone/etc.

- (VI) Look for missing anaphora, using context. Often times words/phrases are left out if the author thinks they will be implied. This is a very frequent phenomenon; e.g., *I went to the demon store, but I didn't want to* is “short for” *I went to the demon store, but I didn't want to go to the demon store*. In complicated sentences these abbreviations can get lost unless they're being explicitly tracked.
- (VII) Look up any and all words you don't know, and even words you do know. (The OED through the library website and wiktionary.org are reliable and relatively comprehensive.)

3.2 Tips for Close Reading

Once analyzed grammatically/syntactically, sentences, and larger texts, can be understood and analyzed in broader terms—their effects, devices, and purposes. Close reading is the analytical practice of trying to explicate literally all of a text's features, in a (relatively) objective way, in order to understand and describe the text's “meaning”. The initial assumption of close reading is that any noticed textual element is fair game for analysis—everything can be taken as “intentional” and important (though there are still varying levels of priority in texts). All statements made in this mode should be based on and supported by the text itself and not by anything outside the text (i.e., not personal beliefs/reactions or general/philosophical statements). This is a very difficult and often unintuitive skill to learn, so it requires practice. Here are crucial aspects to look for when close reading.

(I) ‘literal’ content

- (A) What are the basic ‘facts’ of the text? Who/what is speaking and/or being described? What is the setting? What is the basic purpose/form/genre of the text? How/where is punctuation/formatting used?

(II) diction

- (A) How are the parts of speech used? Make note of verbs, nouns, and other parts of speech and how they are used and organized. Are there any patterns?
- (B) What level of word choice is used? Is the text composed of ‘simple’/‘everyday’ or ‘elevated’/‘poetic’ words? Are there a lot of scientific words or jargon? Are the words more abstract (denoting concepts) or concrete (denoting materials)?
- (C) Are there any words which imply similar or opposing meanings? Do meanings overlap? Are there semantic patterns? What are the words' etymologies and (how) are they being invoked?

(15) examples of word levels

- a. the lord ate like a pig ‘everyday’
- b. the potentate engorged his maw ‘poetic’
- c. the feudal administrator overexpanded his transversus abdominis ‘scientific’

(16) examples of semantic patterns

- a. the sewer **gushed**, and the pedestrians **rushed** off
two quick, watery motion verbs
- b. the sewer **gushed**, and the pedestrians **stagnated**
watery motion versus watery rest

(II) figurative language

- (A) metaphor: What things and types of things are being compared? Are the parts equal? Are the metaphors stand-alone or extended throughout the text?
- (B) metonymy: What phenomena are part of other phenomena? What are the containment relationships? Are these relationships consistent or changed throughout the text?
- (C) imagery: Is some kind of scene or picture being offered? Of what? What's its scope/import?
- (D) symbolism: Do some things represent other, abstract ideas?
- (E) Similar to diction, look for overlapping meanings, repetition, oppositions.

(III) attitude tone

- (A) attitude: Is the subject matter being described positively, neutrally, or negatively?
- (B) tone: How is the attitude expressed? What are the speaker's feelings on the matter? Angry, 'objective', personal, hopeful, ironic, etc.

(17) examples of attitude

- a. the sad dog made it home 'positive'
- b. the sad dog went to the house 'neutral'
- c. the sad dog retreated into its owner's home 'negative'

(18) examples of tone

- a. well I'll be, if those ferrets didn't make that insane machine incredulous
- b. the ferrets that made the insane machine must pay condemnatory
- c. an investigation of the machine-making ferrets has commenced 'objective'

(IV) prosody/visuality

- (A) What are the sonic features of the text, formal and informal? Are there rhymes, puns, etc. Does the text sound "like" anything? How are sounds organized?
- (B) What are the visual features of the text, formal and informal? Are there words that look / are spelled the same? Does the text look "like" anything?

(V) style/structure

- (A) How is the text organized? Where are the main and subordinate ideas? Where are the breaks? Is there some global, underlying structure? Does it seem disorganized? Are there competing explicit and implicit structures/logics?

(VI) themes

- (A) What is the text concerned with, broadly speaking? What is it ‘talking about’.
A theme is not a statement or argument and thereby can’t be ‘wrong’, but it is often expressible as a word or small set of words, e.g., ‘love’ or ‘emotions versus thoughts’.

(VII) claims

- (A) What is the text trying to get across, both explicitly and implicitly? A text’s claims can often be thought of as a combination of its themes and its formal properties, especially its structures. How are the themes and the subsets of the themes being related to each other? The most interesting claims are often times implicit, arising from implicit relationships between words and sentences.

(19) example from Katy Perry’s “Teenage Dream”

- a. **explicit claim:** let’s be carefree ‘like’ teenagers → an optimal relationship is intuitive and innocent
- b. **implicit claim:** I’m lonely, and I want you to be emotionally available → regression to childish ideals might be a valid way for undoing more complicated emotional problems

(IX) some common effects/structures to look for

(20) redundant or extra information

- a. appositives (appended or offset information)
 - i. he went to the red store
 - ii. he went to the store, **the red one**
- b. pleonasm (redundant info)
 - i. some geese just hate **all people, everyone, even tout le monde**
- c. periphrasis (a long form when a shorter one is possible)
 - i. in March
 - ii. in **the month of** March

(21) chiasmus: a cross-like structure (A:B::B:A)

- a. been living with **devils and angels** ... been living like **angels and devils**
- Ariana Grande, “Why Try”
- b. the **children_A** have **eaten_B**, yet still **famished_B** are the **parents_A**

(22) prolepsis: use of a word, phrase, etc. sooner than (grammatically) expected

- a. it’s the way I’m feeling I just can’t deny / but I’ve gotta let it go
-Rihanna, “We Found Love”
[“it’s the way I’m feeling” might be the proleptic object of “deny”]

(23) anacoluthon: an abrupt or unexpected change in grammatical structure

- a. a little less conversation / a little more **touch my body**
 - Ariana Grande, “Into You”
 [either “touch my body” is an imperative verb phrase which cannot be nested under “more”, incorrectly leaving “more” without an object, or it is a verb phrase being coerced into use as a noun phrase]
 - b. it’s the way I’m feeling / I just can’t deny / but I’ve gotta let it go
 - Rihanna, “We Found Love”
 [if not proleptic, “deny” expects an object, but the sentence instead switches to a new independent clause]
- (24) ambiguous syntax
- a. yellow diamonds in the light / and we’re standing side by side / as your shadow crosses mine / what it takes to come alive
 - Rihanna, “We Found Love”
 [it’s not clear how these clauses should be combined]
 - b. he goosed the gooser **with a giant duck**
 [it’s unclear whether “a giant duck” is the means by which the agent (i.e., “he”) “goosed”, is an active helper of the agent, or is a particular property of the object (i.e., “the gooser”)]

3.3 Basics of Making Claims and Writing Papers

After doing a close reading / explication, you can start making larger claims based on your findings. A claim is a proposition, i.e., a statement with (supposed) truth-content, that must be argued for and based on the texts at hand. Claims often extend the structures/logics of the texts in order to derive their and the texts’ implications and to thereby evaluate (not judge) or contextually situate the texts. In other words, claims are not merely descriptive but argue for explicit propositions that, strictly speaking, exist outside of but are fully subservient to the texts. A claim-based paper has at least three parts: introduction, body, conclusion. The “five-paragraph essay” form, however, is not an ideal structure for a rigorous academic paper; nor are arguments based on dictionary definitions, general maxims, or personal beliefs productive bases. Remember, also: writing is a difficult skill to learn and takes practice, effort, and time.

(I) introduction

- (A) sets the scene/terms for the paper
- (B) most importantly, it has a thesis, the paper’s main claim, which has three basic parts:
 - (i) the domain of the claim: aspects/parts/sections of the texts/subjects to be discussed
 - (ii) the claim itself: the succinct proposition that’s going to be argued for, that’s either true or false, including the claim’s import w/r/t the texts’ concerns and contexts

- (iii) the means of the claim: the specific types/forms of evidence that will support the claim, e.g., textual structures/logics, motif patterns, textual aporia/solutions, etc.
- (II) body
- (A) a set of paragraphs, each of which is like a mini paper, containing:
 - (i) an initial claim, i.e., a sub-claim with significance for the thesis
 - (ii) evidence and explication of the sub-claim via the text
 - (iii) the purpose, i.e., the direction/scope of the paragraph within the paper's structure
 - (B) paragraphs should be tightly organized, with clear relationships/transitions between them, and every claim should be related to the thesis
 - (C) arguments, generally speaking, should be inductive, rather than deductive; that is, they should work up from textual data rather than apply non-textual ideas to the text
- (III) conclusion
- (A) reprises the thesis, showing how the claim has been argued
 - (B) doesn't merely summarize the preceding: shows what the paper/results imply and the import therein and details what further research is required
- (IV) see separate sheet for tips avoiding plagiarism
- (V) see [this link](#) for many helpful guides on reading and writing
- (VI) pet peeves: features that frequently appear in student writing but that, under essentially all circumstances, should never appear
- (A) irrelevant non-textual claims
 - (i) general/generalizing statements about literature, history, or the world
 - (ii) arguments from personal belief (including moral judgements)
 - (iii) arguments from experience (including reading experiences of the current text)
 - (B) unnecessary methodological signalling (methods that can be assumed)
 - (i) references to the assignment
 - (ii) close-reading signaling (because close-reading can be assumed)
 - (C) vacuous textual signalling w/o further analysis
 - (i) signalling of textual difficulty or ambiguity without analyzing it
 - (ii) references to textual features without describing or analyzing those features
- (25) pet peeve examples
- a. literature has always focused on love (Ai)

- b. people throughout time have used texts to understand their surroundings (Ai)
- c. I think animals are sentient (Aii)
- d. this book presents a bad view of [some religion] (Aii)
- e. the first time I read an entire book ... (Aiii)
- f. when I first read this text ... (Aiii)
- g. for paper two I chose to look at ... (Bi)
- h. I'm responding to prompt X (Bi)
- i. by looking closely at the text, we can ... (Bii)
- j. the text is ambiguous here [w/o detailing the meanings of the passages] (Ci)
- k. this text has complicated sound patterns [w/o describing those patterns] (Cii)